Problem Solving Styles

In general, people try to solve their problems in one of four ways. These are known as problem solving styles. You will probably use a variety of styles, but it is still a good idea to know which style you prefer. To understand what kind of problem solver you are, complete the following questionnaire.

Rank the words or phrases that are listed under each statement.

1-Almost Always | **2-Sometimes** | **3-Seldom** | **4-Never**

1. Things I consider in solving a problem:

1a) _____ views of other people
1b) _____ views of experts
1c) _____ relevant information
1d) _____ personal experience

2. How I usually approach a problem:

2a) _____ talk to people
2b) _____ explore the background
2c) _____ collect facts
2d) _____ try out a solution

3. The way I like to interact with people:

3a) _____ try to convince them
3b) _____ inform them
3c) _____ interview them
3d) _____ challenge them

4. I like problem solving best when I:

4a) _____ weigh alternatives
4b) _____ gather complete data
4c) _____ explore the cause
4d) _____ take decisive action

5. The statement that best expresses my view of problem solving is:

5a) _____ to be successful a solution must be acceptable to everyone involved
5b) _____ we have a lot to learn from our past experiences
5c) _____ solving most problems comes down to figuring out the cause-and-effect relationships
5d) _____ in the real world, you often have to solve a problem without a complete understanding of what has caused it

To see what your style is, write the scores from the questions above next to the corresponding letters in the following section. Your lowest score on the survey indicates your preferred style.

1a) _____	1b) _____	1c) _____	1d) _____
2a) _____	2b) _____	2c) _____	2d) _____
3a) _____	3b) _____	3c) _____	3d) _____
4a) _____	4b) _____	4c) _____	4d) _____
5a) _____	5b) _____	5c) _____	5d) _____
Total: _____ (D)	**Total: _____ (P)**	**Total: _____ (De)**	**Total: _____ (C)**

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SCORES:

(D) Diplomat

_____ my score

- Interested in reaching consensus (when people all agree)
- Learns best from talking to those involved
- Often values opinions more than facts
- Focuses on practical solutions
- Can be very persuasive
- *Needs to guard against missing timelines as a result of taking too much time gathering opinions*

(P) Professor

_____ my score

- Interested in theories
- Seeks a lot of background information
- Learns from relationships to other situations
- Values detachment from issues (tries to be very objective)
- Relates to others by giving and getting information
- *Needs to guard against indecision and impracticality (always waiting for more information)*

(De) Detective

_____ my score

- Interested in finding the cause of the problem
- Focuses on relevant facts
- Prefers to make direct observations of situations
- Tends to follow a consistent method or process
- Tries to establish clear cause-and-effect relationships
- *Needs to guard against inflexibility and insensitivity to people*

(C) Champion

_____ my score

- Interested in results
- Finds a solution by trying one out
- Wants to achieve success without help from others
- Trusts his or her instincts
- Good in crisis situations when there is no time for analysis
- *Needs to guard against impulsiveness and uncooperativeness*

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